and their obsession with procreation "intriguing". "The only time my mom educated me, her then 38-year-old daughter, on sex, or various sexual positions to be precise, was when I was trying to get pregnant. Out of the many gynaecologists we visited, not one asked us about our sex life; it was always about the frequency of 'relations'," says Jyoti. "That said, things are changing gradually. We are taking baby steps, pun intended."



Pregnant cop Neha Dhupia tries to take down a vigilante in *A Thursday*

A LONG GESTATION

At long last, Bollywood seems to have shed its inhibitions about depicting pregnancy. Citing "the torture porn" and "source of sadism" that was *Meri Aawaz Suno* (1981) and *Souten* (1983) for its "self-abjection and masochism", Aysha Iqbal Viswamohan, professor of film studies and literature at IIT Madras, points out how the representation of pregnancy in Hindi films has ranged "from sublime to melodramatic; and also, ridiculous to farcical". It was in 1983 again that audiences were introduced to the concept of surrogacy in *Doosri Dulhan* (1983), in which Sharmila Tagore and Victor Banerjee play a couple who rope in a prostitute (Shabana Azmi) to have their child. The melodramatic arc thrived even in the 1990s. In the blockbuster *Hum Aapke Hain Koun...!* (1994), the pregnancy of Renuka Shahane's character went from eliciting collective happiness to extreme tragedy, while Madhuri Dixit's character in *Prem Granth* (1996) stood condemned for choosing to have a child born out of rape.

Globalisation, exposure to international cinema and OTT platforms heralded a more progressive and candid approach to pregnancy in cinema, Viswamohan adds. Come the noughties, and the pregnant woman became leading lady. Kundan Shah's *Kya Kehna* (2000) had the teenage Preity Zinta character having a child out of wedlock. Meghna Gulzar's directorial debut, *Filhaal* (2002), revisited the subject of surrogacy even though it failed to strike a chord with audiences. *Salaam Namaste* (2005) had Zinta playing a pregnant character again, this time in Australia, with her live-in partner (played by Saif Ali Khan) not keen to take on the new role of a father. In *Kahaani* (2012), Sujoy Ghosh would deploy pregnancy to make his leading lady (Vidya Balan) appear more vulnerable.

The industry's endorsement of "parenthood through surrogacy" and bringing the "discourse of pregnancy —conventional or otherwise—to the mainstream", be it in books on pregnancy penned by the Kapoor sisters Karisma and Kareena, or Kalki Koechlin or on social media, has only taken the narrative forward, says Viswamohan.

IIT MADRAS FILM STUDIES PROFESSOR AYSHA IQBAL SAYS EARLIER 'PREGNANCY FILMS' RANGED FROM TORTURE PORN (*MERI AAWAZ SUNO*) TO SELF-ABJECTION EXERCISES (*SOUTEN*)

GREAT EXPECTATIONS

There's no telling how long Bollywood's fascination with pregnancy will last. Meanwhile, it is heartening to see a pregnant woman appearing as just another character in films, as in the recently released *A Thursday* on Disney+ Hotstar, where Neha Dhupia was actually pregnant when the thriller was shot. Pregnancy has now become more than a trope, and audiences are getting to see women deftly juggling mood swings and changes in the body with personal ambitions.

There's still a long way to go. Aware that entertainment takes precedence over realism, Dr Jatin Shah doesn't expect "strong scientific content" from filmmakers, the delivery scene in *3 Idiots* being a case in point. "Films showing sperm mix-ups or a sperm donor producing dozens of babies (*Vicky Donor*) show IVF in a bad light," he says. He would also like films to showcase the suffering of infertile couples, how IVF can give them a child and confidence, how freezing eggs can enable late pregnancies and how surrogacy empowers poor women to feed and educate their children. It is a field pregnant with possibilities, if Shah's bank of ideas is anything to go by. ■